

**MOHIT BURMAN**CHAIRMAN, DABUR
INDIA LTD

“The shift to professional, non-family succession was not a rejection of family legacy; it was a reimagining of the [succession] process”

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ago. Meanwhile, Asian Paints and Havells India, despite promoter ownership, have been professionally managed for years.

The guiding principle, Burman says, has always been that the organisation comes first. “We were among the first to realise that the promoters should provide a long-term vision to the company, and that professionals should manage the show efficiently,” Burman told *Business Today*, adding that the decision to hand over management control was taken in the best interest of Dabur.

It was also a conscious decision about future generations. “It was decided, way back in 1998, that none of the Burman family members would get an entry into Dabur.”

Burman admits the transition was not without its challenges. He recalls the difficulty of stepping back, especially in “attracting the right professionals to lead a business still largely perceived as family-run.” Yet, the move proved prescient. “Each member now manages their own enterprise, creating new legacies while the family continues to play a trusteeship role in preserving and growing Dabur as an institution.”

The Dabur story reflects a quiet revolution underway in India’s family businesses. Long seen as synonymous with dynastic succession, they are now redrawing the rules of continuity. According to HSBC’s report, *Family-owned businesses in Asia: Harmony through succession planning*, while 88% of entrepreneurs trust the next generation with family wealth, 45% don’t expect them to run the business. Only 7% of heirs, in fact, feel bound to take it up.

This shift is far from uniquely Indian. Around the world, leading family enterprises are choosing

professional leadership to balance heritage with scale. British multinational venture capital conglomerate Virgin Group has been led since 2011 by non-family CEO Josh Bayliss, while Richard Branson and his family continue to provide vision and ownership. At LEGO, the Danish Kirk Kristiansen family continues to own the group, but the reins have passed to non-family chief executive Niels B Christensen. In the US, Cargill, one of the country’s largest family-owned businesses, remains majority-owned by the Cargill-MacMillan family but is professionally run, with Brian Sikes serving as CEO and Board Chair.

REWIRING SUCCESSION

Industry watchers say the writing is clear: lineage is giving way to value (or talent from outside).

“The next generation is globally exposed, less interested in ‘running’ legacy firms, and more focused on ‘transforming’ their current businesses or creating new ventures through family offices,” says Sandeep Bhalla, Senior Partner & Head of Consulting, of global consulting firm Korn Ferry India.

Founders also recognise that scaling up and governance are best left to professional CEOs.

“For today’s heirs, legacy is less about holding the corner office and more about shaping the future through ownership, values, and vision,” Bhalla adds. He contends the key drivers for this shift include global exposure and new aspirations, with next-gen leaders, often educated abroad, being less tied to legacy firms and more drawn to entrepreneurship, venture capital, and future-focused sectors like climate, fintech, and digital innovation.

Founder pragmatism and governance pressures also play a role,